

3.12 Tracing a formula

There are a number of ways to trace a formula so you can check it for errors if needed or just review the logical steps it takes in calculating the result.

Formulas can be evaluated step by step. This will show you the logical steps taken in calculating the result, and is especially useful when you are dealing with large, complex nested formulas, which can easily get very confusing.



Step by step formula evaluation

To evaluate a cell with a formula, first select the cell and click on the Evaluate button on the Formula Auditing group in the Formulas tab. In the resulting dialog box, you'll be able to see the entire formula first. Click on the Evaluate button, and the first calculation in the sequence would be calculated. Once you are satisfied with the result and the logic of the step, click on the Evaluate button again to go to the next part of the formula to be evaluated... and so on.

This process will help you confirm that there are no incorrect references and that the logical steps involved in the formula calculation are as you want them to them.

You can also trace a formula visually by looking up the Precedent or Dependent cells. Precedent cells are referred to by a formula in another cells. Dependent cells have formulas referring to other cells. The Trace Precedents and Trace Dependents commands will graphically display the relationships that a formula has with other cells.

To view the Precedence and Dependence of a formula, first go to Excel Options in the Office Button, select Advanced, and scroll